Knee pain: what the evidence says works — and what doesn't

From Kotsu (kotsuhealth.com) — health claims graded A to D against the research by an orthopaedic surgeon. A = solid evidence · B = likely · C = unproven · D = myth (the claim is not supported).

What the guideline puts first

NICE guideline NG226 (2022) on osteoarthritis: the core treatments are **therapeutic exercise** and **weight management** (if appropriate) (rec. 1.2.2). It says **do not offer** glucosamine (1.4.6), intra-articular hyaluronan injections (1.4.9), or arthroscopic lavage or debridement (1.7.1). nice.org.uk/guidance/ng226

Popular claims, graded

Grade	The claim people repeat	Key study
D Myth	Strength training is bad for older adults' joints	Liu et al. 2009
D Myth	Walking wears out a knee that already has arthritis	Lo et al. 2022
D Myth	Recreational running wears out your knees	Alentorn-Geli et al. 2017
B Likely	Every pound you lose takes about four pounds of load off your knee with each step	Messier et al. 2005
C Unproven	A knee brace relieves knee arthritis pain	Duivenvoorden et al. 2015
D Myth	Wedge insoles relieve knee arthritis pain	Bennell et al. 2011
D Myth	Glucosamine rebuilds or regrows knee cartilage	Wandel et al. 2010
D Myth	Gel (hyaluronic acid) injections give meaningful pain relief for knee arthritis	Pereira et al. 2022
D Myth	A cortisone shot gives lasting relief for knee arthritis	Jüni et al. 2015
D Myth	Arthroscopic surgery gives lasting relief for a degenerative (worn) knee	Moseley et al. 2002
C Unproven	A noisy, cracking knee means arthritis is coming	Couch et al. 2025
C Unproven	Changes in the weather make joint pain worse	Jena et al. 2017
D Myth	A knee replacement only lasts 10–15 years	Evans et al. 2019

Get seen urgently if the knee is hot, red and swollen or you have a fever; get an injured knee examined if, for example, you can't take four steps on it or bend it to a right angle. Self-check: kotsuhealth.com/knee-pain-navigator/

General health information, not medical advice. Full sources for every grade are on each article page. Search every verdict: kotsuhealth.com/verdicts/